

MAKE A DIFFERENCE

BRIDGING THE GAP

CARE TODAY launches a scholarship scheme and a boat service in the tsunami-hit Nicobar islands and also plans to build a community centre for the homeless



SYMPATHY WAVE: A group of students from Nicobar at Christian College, Chennai

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A massive earthquake, measuring 8.9 on the Richter Scale with its epicentre off the Sumatra Islands, triggered the tsunami that wreaked havoc in the Andaman and Nicobar islands in December 2004. The deadly tidal waves caused widespread destruction and left many dead. The Nicobar islands were the worst-hit. In the immediate aftermath of the tsunami, CARE TODAY rushed to help restore basic services in the area—first by supporting an emergency medical team from St. John's Hospital, Bangalore, and then by introducing a boat service for two months on the Katchal island.

The Nicobar islands, clustered into three groups, stretch across 150 km from north to south. The northernmost is Car Nicobar which is the district headquarters; the Nancowry group of islands including Katchal and Komorta form the centre, while the southernmost tip includes Great Nicobar and Little Nicobar. These islands are poorly connected with remote settlements and Great and Little Nicobars have no access to either road or jetty. These were destroyed by the tsunami. Poor connectivity hampered the rehabilitation process. Almost three years after the tsunami, the affected communities are still staying in temporary shelters in and around the Campbell Bay.

CARE TODAY revisited the Nicobars in August and held consul-

tations with the stakeholders in the rehabilitation process. We have, since, begun work on three projects to hasten relief work. A scholarship scheme has been launched for Nicobari students pursuing higher studies. Under it, a sum of Rs 2,000 is provided to them every month for a year. A total of Rs 12 lakh has been approved for the purpose and 35 youth are at present the beneficiaries of the scheme.

To improve connectivity, a boat service has also been started between Campbell Bay and settlements on Great and Little Nicobars. The service, being run by local NGO Parirakshak and a group of Nicobari youth called the Dosti Group, connects the settlements with the Campbell Bay twice a month, and enables movement of people and material. CARE TODAY has approved a sum of Rs 1.2 lakh for the project for a period of three months. We have also approved the purchase of a 32x8 ft 16

horsepower boat for the purpose. That apart, a sum of Rs 15 lakh has been approved towards the construction of a community centre for the Nicobaris, at Campbell Bay.

CARE TODAY thanks its readers for contributions, totalling Rs 2,79,04,253. Out of this, Rs 1,99,13,947 was spent till October 2007. The contributions helped us in our efforts to make a difference in the lives of those left bereft on the shore of life. ■



ANCHORED: Boat service in the Nicobars